Trevor White
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Day 5 of the 12 Days of Madness: 3-point shooting.

Does 3pt shooting matter more in March?

Stick around till the end to see how the expected field of '26 stacks up.

12:05 AM · Mar 11, 2026 · **9** Views

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Metrics used for Day 5:

-3PRATE: the rate at which a team takes 3s
-3P%: the rate at which a team makes 3s
-3P%D: the rate at which opponents make 3s against that defense

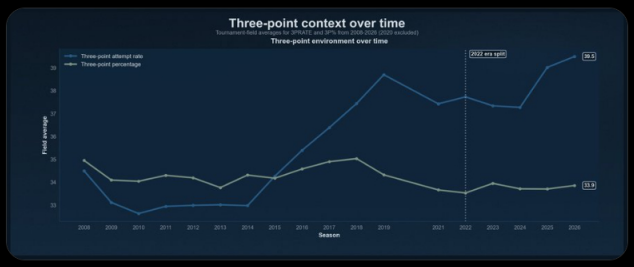
All sourced from barttorvik.com.

1 7

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Unsurprisingly, the field now takes far more 3s than it did in 2008, while the increased shots have come at an efficiency cost.

This charts illustrates how there are large differences in how 3-pointers affect the game today vs 2008, and our analysis should respect that.

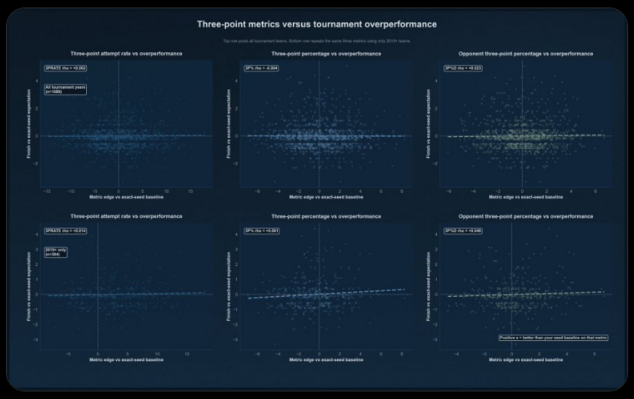


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Over the full sample, none of the three metrics is a huge standalone seed-adjusted edge.

Whereas, once looking in the modern 3-pt era, we see the insight strengthen for 3pt % on both offense and defense.



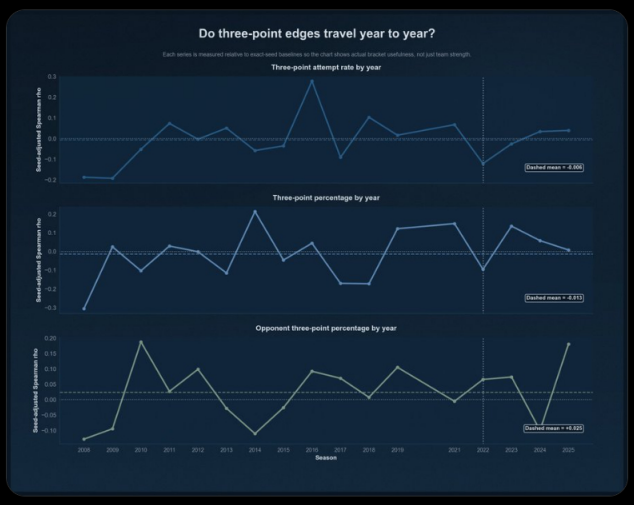
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The trend of 3pt insight shows variation and an inconsistent story over time.

While it seems 3pt % helps on O and D a little more in the modern era, the

trend still varies year to year.

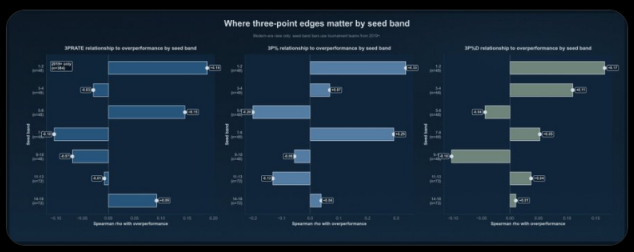


1 3

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Next, how does the effect of 3pt metrics vary by seed in the modern-era?

Here we see 3p%D the most consistent across seed lines. While all of them appear important for top seeds.



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Here we look at whether shooting more 3's or less is helpful for strong shooting teams.

This reveals that if a team does shoot a high volume of 3's, they better shoot consistently. And it looks like those with very high rate and % tend to benefit the most.

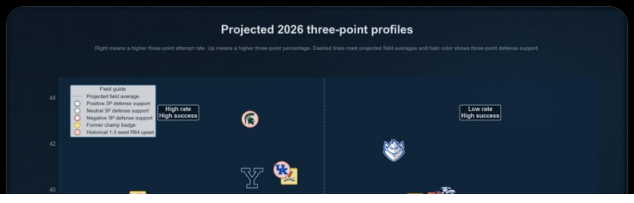


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Former winners have rarely shot the 3-ball at a high rate, casting doubt on the ceiling of the red teams.

Whereas Iowa State and Purdue sit in a danger zone of top seeds to get upset round 1.



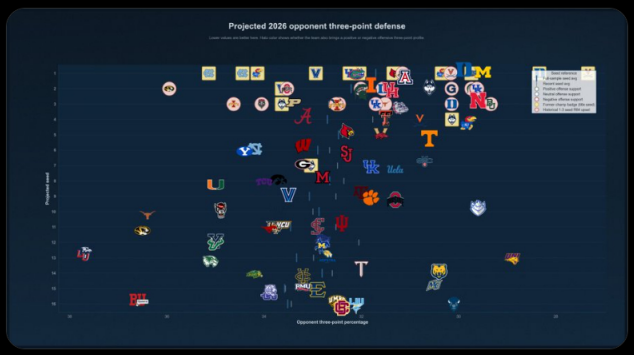


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Plotting former champs doesn't give any insights on former champs. But earlier we saw 3pt D may be important, especially for high seeds like Duke and Michigan.

Whereas Northern Iowa could give a 3pt dependent matchup some trouble. And Saint Louis thrives on 3's all-around.



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Thanks for reading, see you again tomorrow for day 6: Rebounding.

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USD Baseball Analytics • Sr. Data Scientist @Good360USA • Other sports data (is it March again yet?)

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